

and a good media player. For the price (Rs 19,897), the SE990i has an extensive feature list.

Blackberry's Pearl features a compact yet functional QWERTY keypad and a roller-ball-type joystick that makes navigation a snap. One look at the screen icons will tell you this is no multimedia phone—very business-like, with loads of applications pre-installed. For example, Yahoo! Messenger and Google Talk are set to run out of the box. The Pearl is really well-built, and the compact form factor was something Blackberry sorely needed in their line-up.

Performance

The Sony Ericsson P990i offered some swift Wi-Fi transfers—to the tune of 1.75 MBps! This PDA offers great music quality while suffering a bit in on call quality.

During the voice clarity tests, the HTC phones revealed where their true genes lie—and it's definitely not as a handset. Functionality—yes, call clarity—needs to improve.

The best *phone* in this category was the Blackberry Pearl. In fact, it was much better than anything else in the previous category as well. Amazing... no voice distortion even while moving from zone 2 to zone 1! It does have its weak points, though—like the mediocre camera.

Our Conclusion

It's smart looking, and it's functional, not to mention nifty—and more, it's our Best Buy Silver: the **HTC Touch**—unbeatable value for money at under Rs 20,000. Definitely for you if you want a flashy PDA with almost all the features.

If you're looking for a multimedia-rich PDA, the **Sony Ericsson P990i** will fit the bill. Just remember a belt case is a must, as this phone won't fit tight jeans—we suggest you avoid trying! A good camera, a great media player, two keypads, a good screen, and all the connectivity you'll need—Digit Best Buy Gold belongs here!

The **RIM Blackberry Pearl** is just as flashy as the HTC Touch, but its talents are more subtle, less in-your-face. It's very functional, very Internet friendly, and it has a stellar antenna to keep your phone calls connected almost everywhere. If all this appeals, then by all means, take the plunge. We feel the price is a little steep, especially considering some of the other phones in this test. Do not forget that Blackberry phones aren't available off the market shelf. They are sold with select service provider schemes.

Corporate Mates

PDA Phones (Above Rs 25,000) Features

Being a corporate user, you'll probably scoff at many of the contestants in the previous two categories. You receive a hundred mails a day. A QWERTY keypad and a fully-functional document assistant aren't something you flash about—you actually use every feature to the fullest. In such a case, money isn't the sole concern—functionality and feature-convergence is.

The GPS-ready **ASUS P535** is a standout looker. It's compact, has exceptional build quality, and sports a dark grey body that suits boardroom

environments. It comes with the richest software bundle we've seen in a while. Take a look at Voice Commander 2.0, a remote control / presentation utility, a GPS utility with detailed maps, an encryption software that protects all your prying data from prying eyes, and a business card scan utility that works really well. A 2 MP camera with auto-focus hasn't been forgotten.

HTC's C800 is another solidly-built device with pleasing aesthetics, except for the all-chrome buttons on the front. The full QWERTY that slides out from the side is a big plus. It's large enough for the ham-handed, and it doesn't add to the dimensions of the phone.

O2's Xda Zinc has a form factor identical to that of the P535 and the C800, but like the former, it misses out on a full QWERTY keypad. Button ergonomics are good, though some may find that the light grey body catches stains a little too easily.

The old man in this test was **IMate's Jasjar**. Despite the fact that the Jasjar is essentially a 2005 model, it has all the features needed to make it here, including a huge 3.7-inch screen that actually sports an unheard-of VGA (640 x 480) resolution. Then there's the full QWERTY keypad that is revealed when you open the laptop-like lid. The best-laid-out QWERTY in test, period! It uses the now-ancient 802.11b Wi-Fi protocol, and at 285 gm is by far the heaviest PDA now in our labs.

Nokia's Communicator series gets a new flagship—the **E90** exemplifies what the Communicators are all about. The hinge quality has been beefed up, the camera now captures 3.2 megapixels, and both screens now display 16 million colours. Incidentally, the smaller outer screen is very crisp and ultra-usable—something earlier Communicators missed out on. The keypad is typically Communicator—good tactile feedback and well-laid-out.

RIM's Blackberry 8800 is their flagship, and it shows: a well-laid-out QWERTY, and all the great features aboard the Pearl minus the camera that RIM figures corporates could do without anyway. But mysteriously, Wi-Fi is absent. When you take into consideration that this phone will be part of a service provider bundle, this seems to make sense. Browse using GPRS if you must!

Performance

Despite our best efforts at signal scrambling, the Blackberry 8800 wasn't fazed one bit—signal quality was even better than that of the brilliant Pearl. This 8800 loses out on multimedia performance—music quality isn't really acceptable—you just have to live with the fact. The screen is good, however, and that makes for a good visual experience, as we discovered in our video playback tests.

Nokia's E90, too, has good signal quality, and is snappy to boot. Its camera does surprisingly well, and at 2.1 MBps on our

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AUGUST 2007



Nokia Communicator E90
The new brick!